entered India, the caste system stayed firmly in place, with the exception of those Hindus who converted to Islam.

In addition to the original four castes, 25,000 more sub-castes were created to specifically address each niche role with the community. Theoretically, if a person born into the Shudra caste, whose family's job is making bricks, then Shudra brick-making is the destiny of all that person's children, grandchildren, great-grandchildren, and so on. Technically speaking, Hinduism does leave room for passion to play a role in optional sub-castes; though, the reality is, by and large, that where one is born, one remains. Though there are rare exceptions to the rule, castes effectively oppressed the poor and kept the wealthy just as influential as were their ancestors. Personal ambition meant very little unless you were Brahman.

When the Maratha Hindus reclaimed much of the subcontinent for their own purposes, the castes were reinforced with vigor as Hindus had been waiting for an opportunity to fully practice their religion and lifestyle for centuries. Castes weren't just a traditional part of societal organization; they could actually be interpreted as the will of the universe for a culture that believed in reincarnation. Hindu texts teach their followers that the soul exists despite the death of the body and that one's soul can be reborn in new bodies again and again, either in hell, in heaven, or on earth. Through successive earthly incarnations, the soul is born into a caste according to its karma (in this case used to mean "the total sum of one's actions") and therefore has the chance to become a better person in each new life. Theoretically, one's soul might first live on earth as a Dalit and through good deeds achieve the Shudra label in its next life until finally reaching the top of the hierarchy and ultimately become "moksha," the final spiritual level at which point no more lives are necessary. At moksha, one reaches purity and immortality.

On a spiritual level, these are admirable concepts. In practice, they imposed a highly unfair burden on members of the lower castes or those branded untouchables. Much like the lower, middle, and upper class divides of other societies, those at the bottom are much more plentiful than those at the top. The system established itself just as economy demanded; more than 90 percent of Indians have traditionally belonged to the untouchable group or the Shudra level, where they worked long hours in agriculture, manufacturing, or garbage and waste management. Meanwhile, precious few enjoyed the benefits of birth into the Brahmin group, in whose embrace